Traditional Chinese Medicine at Tong Keow Healthcare

Everyday care, convenience, localisation and pattern differentiation

GEC1044 Group Fieldwork Report • Revised complete draft

TD3 Group 2
Lou Yu Luke · Chang Tze Yi Othniel · Li Xudong
Curtis Chang Kai Xian · Hu Zhixuan Shirley
Tutor Lin Shi Ting

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Block 809 Hougang Central #01-170 Singapore 530809
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Revision note

This revision organises the findings around everyday care, convenience and localisation, with all seven survey records retained in Appendix A. Staff accounts, photographs and our interpretations remain distinct. Industry examples are identified as promotional, journalistic or public-relations sources. Section 6 uses the contrasting ginseng profiles to explain the difference between retail advice and pattern differentiation. It also connects the themes to Tong Keow's mixed retail model and Hougang neighbourhood while retaining the simpler language of the readability revision.

1 Introduction

At Tong Keow's Hougang outlet, dried herbs and packaged soups sit alongside grains and other everyday foods. During our visit, a staff member described customers buying products for nourishment, throat comfort, fatigue and concerns about their daily routines. This combination of food shopping and health care is the starting point of our report. We explore how a neighbourhood medicine hall brings Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM) into ordinary life.

Our argument is that TCM continues through changes in how people encounter and use it. Familiar soup ingredients connect it to household meals. Preselected packs and prepared products make it easier to buy and prepare. Local branding, manufacturing and a mixed food range give it a place in Singapore's retail setting. The following sections develop these themes using our observations, the staff interview and relevant literature. Appendix A contains the full survey findings.

2 Fieldwork and the neighbourhood medicine hall

2.1 How we conducted the fieldwork

We visited Tong Keow on 13 September 2026, photographed the displays and conducted a semi-structured interview with one staff member. We used the interview transcripts, presentation script and photographs to prepare this report. Where the transcripts contain recognition errors, we paraphrase the clear statements. References to the staff member refer to this interview (Tong Keow staff member, personal communication, September 13, 2026).

Throughout the report, “the staff member described” refers to the interview, while descriptions of displays refer to our photographs. Phrases such as “we read this as” introduce our analysis. Published sources provide historical, demographic and industry context. The staff’s descriptions of popular and lower-demand products are informal accounts; we did not collect sales records or interview customers.

2.2 Tong Keow and its mixed retail model

The group presentation traces Tong Keow’s original Toa Payoh shop to 1968, consistent with a directory’s account of its fiftieth anniversary in 2018. The business records have later dates: Tong Keow Medicine and Provision Shop was registered on 29 March 1975, and Tong Keow Medical Hall Pte. Ltd. was incorporated on 1 January 2015. Both list 70 Lorong 4 Toa Payoh #01-333, Toa Payoh Vista, as their registered address. Their business classifications cover Chinese medicine shops and provision or convenience stores (codes 47723 and 47102). This helps explain the combination of medicinal and food products in the shop (Accounting and Corporate Regulatory Authority [ACRA], n.d.; Healthcare.com.sg, n.d.; Singapore Department of Statistics [DOS], n.d.).

The tutor described Tong Keow as a chain, and the directory links its Toa Payoh and Hougang outlets. At Hougang, we photographed Tong Keow branding on soup packs alongside herbs, grains and other foods. We read this as a medicine hall organised around both medicinal and culinary shopping. The branding connects the branch to the wider business, although we did not investigate how the branches buy or assemble their stock.

2.3 Hougang and the customers described by staff

The staff member described customers as mainly Chinese, middle-aged and older, including people in their forties and fifties. Hougang’s residential setting provides useful context. The planning area had 228,140 residents in June 2024. HDB separately reported 57,557 dwelling units and 165,450 residents in its Hougang flats as at 31 March 2024. These totals cover different housing populations (DOS, 2024; Housing & Development Board [HDB], 2024, pp. 11–12).

Hougang Central, the smaller subzone around the outlet, had about 4,620 residents in June 2025. Using the official rounded age-band totals, around 1,070 were aged 65 or above, roughly 23% of the population (DOS, 2025). This places the shop within a neighbourhood with a substantial older population, alongside the middle-aged customers described by staff.

Chua et al. (2025) provide another view of neighbourhood life. Their 647 Hougang respondents had an average age of 69 and had lived in the area for an average of 22 years. Seventeen per cent lived alone, compared with 15% of 552 respondents in Taman Jurong; that difference was not statistically significant. The long residence in this sample gives context to our reading of Tong Keow as part of an established neighbourhood, although the study did not examine shopping at the outlet.

Hougang also has a history of Teochew settlement, recorded in the National Heritage Board’s account of Tou Mu Kung and its fishing, farming and rubber-growing community (National Heritage Board [NHB], n.d.). Together, this history and the residential setting help us understand the place of a Chinese medicine hall in local community life. The staff’s account remains our source for the shop’s current customer mix.

3 Everyday care and food therapy

3.1 Herbs in household meals

The staff member named Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates and goji as common soup ingredients. The presentation also included ginseng/American ginseng and monk fruit among its eight common-herb entries. Table A1 gives their traditional profiles and separates the two kinds of ginseng. In the shop, prepared ingredient packs and a family cooking image on the soup display placed these materials in the familiar setting of a household meal (Figures 1–2).

We read this overlap between herbs and food through the ideas of nourishing life, 养生, and medicine and food sharing a source, 药食同源. Soup offers a way to encounter TCM through cooking and everyday nourishment. Lim et al.'s (2005) survey of complementary and alternative medicine in multiracial Singapore also identified health maintenance as a significant reason for use. Yang's (2022) history places Chinese medicine within Singapore's changing community and institutional life. These readings help explain why the food side of the medicine hall matters to our fieldwork.

3.2 Soup packs and light nourishment

Our presentation organised the soup findings into five labels: Qing Bu Liang 清补凉, Dang Shen–Huang Qi soup 党参北芪补气汤, Yu Zhu–Huai Shan soup 玉竹淮山润燥汤, goji–red date soup 枸杞红枣养生汤 and Five Finger Fig soup 五指毛桃健脾汤. Table A4 retains these labels and the ingredients available in our records. The interview named common ingredients, but we did not obtain complete recipes for all five soups.

The staff account and presentation associated these soups with digestion, moistening and light nourishment, 清补. This is an everyday approach to replenishment, distinct from the stronger tonification described as 大补. In our reading, the soup packs bring this language into ordinary meals. Traditional references to the Spleen and Liver describe TCM functions and relationships, rather than exact equivalents of biomedical organs (World Health Organization [WHO], 2022).

3.3 Singapore weather and the appeal of lighter soups

The staff member linked monk fruit's popularity and lighter soups to Singapore's environment. Meteorological Service Singapore describes high temperatures, abundant rainfall and high humidity throughout the year, with monsoon and inter-monsoon periods (Meteorological Service Singapore [MSS], n.d.). The presentation's phrase "without four distinct seasons" describes this tropical setting in broad terms. The link between the weather and product demand comes from the staff member's explanation.

The Suwen reading connects seasonal habits with maintaining health (Unschuld & Tessenow, 2011, pp. 45–57). We read the staff's explanation as a local use of this environmental reasoning: lighter soups and cooling drinks are discussed in relation to Singapore's weather. The descriptions remain distinct—for example, Yu Zhu is associated with moistening dryness, rather than removing dampness.

4 Convenience and changing consumption forms

4.1 Easier preparation and the staff account of younger buyers

The staff member described younger customers as buying fewer raw herbs and preferring teas, supplements and simpler preparations. Table A2 retains the eight categories from our presentation, ranging from ginseng

tonics and herbal teas to soup packs, mood-support products and medicated oils. This account gives us a view of changing purchases from behind the counter; customer interviews would be needed to explore the reasons for those choices.

The packaged products show what convenience means in practice. In a dried soup pack, someone has already selected and portioned the ingredients, leaving the buyer to cook them. Staff can explain the pack's intended use, while the household completes the preparation. Capsules offer another form, with less preparation at home. The photographed multi-buy promotion adds a familiar retail feature to the soup display. Convenience here concerns the work involved in choosing and preparing a product, as well as its packaging.

4.2 Comparative industry examples

Other businesses offer useful comparisons. Nanyang Polytechnic describes Heng Foh Tong's redesign of herbal drinks for millennials (Nanyang Polytechnic [NYP], n.d.). Amacha markets TCM-inspired milk teas, and a founder interview reported more than 150,000 cups sold in eight months (Amacha, n.d.; Angelynn T., 2026). Teck Soon's owner reported a 30% sales increase after moving herbs from drawers to storefront displays in 1982 (Chin, 2024). Eu Yan Sang also offers a halal product category (Eu Yan Sang, n.d.). These are promotional, journalistic or institutional public-relations accounts, not peer-reviewed studies. They describe deliberate changes in product formats and displays, and serve as industry comparisons rather than data on young Singaporeans or Tong Keow's customers.

4.3 Products for daily pressures and products needing more guidance

The staff member associated late nights, long work hours, stress and prolonged phone use with liver-care or mood-support products. The supplied photograph shows Nature's Green Mind Soothe Capsules as an example, although the interview did not name a brand. Its packaging uses the familiar TCM language of soothing Liver-related constraint, 疏肝解郁. We read this as a way of presenting a product through concerns about daily life. "Liver" in this description refers to the TCM vocabulary discussed earlier.

The staff's account of work pressure needs to be read alongside broader labour data. Average usual weekly working hours among employed residents fell from 44.2 a decade earlier to 41.4 in 2025 (Ministry of Manpower [MOM], 2026). The interview therefore concerns staff impressions of customers' routines and stress, rather than a national increase in working hours.

The lower-demand examples point to the importance of preparation and guidance. The presentation listed Ban Zhi Lian 半枝莲, specialist herbs used in combinations and strong tonic formulas 大补方 (Table A5). Staff linked their lower appeal to unfamiliarity and the effort of preparing them, while the presentation also discussed the suitability of stronger tonics in Singapore's climate. Staff said that poorly selling items were stocked in smaller quantities. We read these findings as a practical distinction between products that fit easily into daily routines and those that require more explanation or preparation.

5 Localisation through products packaging and cultural contact

5.1 Imported materials and locally made products

The staff member described raw materials as coming mainly from China, citing variety and cost, with limited local cultivation. Our presentation retained five locally linked examples: cactus 仙人掌, roselle 洛神花, patent medicines 中成药, Five Flower Tea 五花茶 and monk-fruit tea 罗汉果茶 (Table A3). Their links to Singapore differ. For the pictured Nature's Green Mind Soothe Capsules, the Health Sciences Authority (HSA) lists Tong

Jum Chew as manufacturer and Singapore as the manufacturing country (HSA, 2025b). This is a locally manufactured finished medicine; the origins of its ingredients were not recorded.

Tong Keow branding and preselected soup materials also give imported herbs a local retail form. We read localisation here as the work of choosing ingredients, portioning them, naming their uses and presenting them for Singapore shoppers. Staff described local processing and packing, although we did not trace the soup packs' supply chain. Cultivation, manufacture and packaging are separate parts of this process, which is why Table A3 records them separately.

Local manufacture and assembly of finished Chinese Proprietary Medicines (CPM) sit within Singapore's regulatory framework. HSA requires the relevant dealer licences and product listing, with manufacturing and assembly facilities subject to licensing and Good Manufacturing Practice requirements (HSA, 2026c, 2026d). This provides context for the locally made capsule example. Raw herbs, foods and soup packs need to be considered according to their own product categories.

5.2 Packaging and the language of trust

Packaging has a practical role in making medicines understandable to buyers. HSA's CPM guidelines require full labelling in English, with any additional language corresponding to it. Labels must include product and ingredient information, batch and expiry details, and the relevant manufacturer, importer or assembler information (HSA, 2025a, section 5). HSA also distinguishes product listing from an assessment of therapeutic efficacy (HSA, 2026b). These rules shape how finished medicines are presented in Singapore.

Liu et al. (2026), studying Chinese herbal medicines sold in Malaysia, discuss how legal requirements shape translated names and therapeutic statements. Their study offers a regional comparison for the relationship between medical vocabulary and consumer communication. In our reading, packaging helps carry that vocabulary into a retail setting, where a buyer encounters a named product and a short description of its use. Singapore's own requirements remain the relevant rules for Tong Keow.

The staff member also emphasised fresh colour and sulphur-free materials. Our cabinet photograph includes a sulphur-free Dang Shen label and a separate American ginseng label (Figure 3). These are examples of the quality information presented to shoppers. We read them as part of how the shop invites trust in its products. HSA's guidance on supplement claims cautions against treating "natural" as a guarantee of safety (HSA, 2026a).

5.3 Different shoppers in a shared space

The staff member described Malay customers buying dessert ingredients and Indian customers buying nuts, alongside a largely Chinese clientele. We did not interview these customers, so their purchases enter the report through the staff account. The food and medicinal range gives people different reasons to visit the same shop.

We read this shared space as a form of everyday cultural contact. A shopper can buy a dessert ingredient without using it as medicine, while another buys a product for nourishment. The medicine hall can therefore become familiar through overlapping shopping routines, even when customers understand its products differently. This develops the presentation's account of cultural change through the ordinary uses of the shop.

6 Bringing the findings together: pattern differentiation and adaptation

6.1 Retail advice and pattern differentiation

Our visit centred on retail advice and household care. Clinical TCM involves assessing a person's signs and symptoms before selecting treatment, a process known as 辨证论治, or pattern differentiation and treatment (WHO, 2022). Table A1 gives a concrete contrast: ginseng has a neutral nature, while American ginseng is cool and nourishes Yin. A customer's description of fatigue alone leaves this choice unresolved. The staff's fatigue–tonic pairing in Table A6 helps explain a retail product association; choosing an individual treatment would require a fuller assessment. We did not observe a clinical consultation.

People may also use TCM alongside other forms of care. MOH reported that nearly 40% of TCM users in the 2022 National Population Health Survey combined TCM and Western medicine for the same condition (Ministry of Health [MOH], 2025). We did not ask Tong Keow's customers about their treatment choices, but this wider context reminds us that a purchase at a medicine hall can be one part of a person's health care.

6.2 How the shop brings TCM into everyday life

Food use gives herbs a familiar purpose, preselected packs reduce preparation work, and packaging explains intended uses. Local branding and manufacture connect some products to Singapore's businesses and regulation. Together, these changes bring TCM into ordinary cooking, shopping and daily care.

Tong Keow's mixed medicine-and-food business gives these activities a shared location. Its branding connects the branch to a wider business, while Hougang's established neighbourhood provides the setting for the clientele described by staff. We see traditional materials presented in forms suited to local household routines.

This reading connects Unschuld's (2018) account of adaptation and Yang's (2022) history with an everyday retail setting: soup displays and packaged products in a shop that also sells food.

7 Limitations

This report draws on one visit and one staff interview. Demand and customer preferences come from staff descriptions; we collected no sales or customer data and made no branch comparison. Neighbourhood statistics describe the surrounding population. The industry accounts provide comparisons, not peer-reviewed evidence.

Complete soup recipes and sourcing and purchasing records were unavailable. The pictured Nature's Green capsules are listed as Singapore-manufactured, but their ingredient origins remain unknown. Physician presence was unclear, and we recorded no consultation, prescription or patient outcome. MOH (2026) provides the wider professional-registration context.

The appendix distinguishes reference profiles and external images from field photographs. Customer interviews and further visits could deepen this account.

8 Conclusion

At Tong Keow, familiar ingredients, soup packs and prepared products sit alongside food. Staff linked this range to nourishment, convenience and customers' routines. Hougang's residential setting and the mixed retail model help explain how these uses share one neighbourhood shop.

In this case, TCM continues through changes in how people encounter and use it. Traditional ingredients take new forms through packaging and preparation, becoming part of shopping and cooking. Retail advice makes products easier to approach, while individual treatment still calls for assessment of the person.

Appendix A Detailed fieldwork evidence

Appendix A retains the detailed survey findings from the group presentation. The tables identify staff-reported uses, traditional reference profiles and the sources of the photographs.

A1 Eight herb entries with separate reference profiles

The presentation groups ginseng and American ginseng in one entry. Table A1 separates their profiles, giving nine rows for the eight reported entries. The field cabinet also labels American ginseng separately.

Table A1 Traditional herb profiles in the eight presentation entries

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 人参 *Ren Shen* Ginseng (root) (PolyU, n.d.-h)	Sweet, slightly bitter; neutral	Heart, Spleen, Lung	Strongly tonifies original Qi; supports Spleen and Lung; generates fluids; calms the spirit.	Poor appetite, fatigue and breathlessness in Qi-deficiency patterns; thirst from fluid depletion.
 西洋参 *Xi Yang Shen* American ginseng (root) (PolyU, n.d.-a)	Sweet, slightly bitter; cool	Heart, Lung, Kidney	Tonifies Qi and nourishes Yin; clears heat; generates fluids.	Fatigue, dry mouth, thirst and cough in Qi–Yin deficiency with deficiency heat.
 党参 *Dang Shen* Codonopsis (root) (PolyU, n.d.-m)	Sweet; neutral	Spleen, Lung	Tonifies middle Qi; strengthens Spleen and Lung functions.	Poor appetite, loose stools, fatigue and shortness of breath in Spleen–Lung Qi deficiency.
 黄芪 *Huang Qi* Astragalus / milkvetch (root) (PolyU, n.d.-l)	Sweet; warm	Spleen, Lung	Tonifies Qi; strengthens exterior defence; promotes fluid discharge and tissue repair.	Fatigue, poor appetite and loose stools in Qi deficiency; spontaneous sweating from weak exterior defence.

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 玉竹 *Yu Zhu* Fragrant Solomon's seal (rhizome) (PolyU, n.d.-g)	Sweet; slightly cold	Lung, Stomach	Nourishes Yin; moistens dryness; generates fluids and relieves thirst.	Dry cough, dry throat and thirst in Lung–Stomach Yin deficiency.
 淮山 / 山药 *Huai Shan / Shan Yao* Chinese yam (rhizome) (PolyU, n.d.-f)	Sweet; neutral	Spleen, Lung, Kidney	Supports Spleen and Stomach; generates fluids and benefits Lung; strengthens Kidney.	Poor appetite and persistent diarrhoea in Spleen deficiency; chronic cough in Lung deficiency; frequent urination in Kidney deficiency.
 红枣 / 大枣 *Hong Zao / Da Zao* Red dates / jujube (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-d)	Sweet; warm	Spleen, Stomach	Tonifies middle Qi; nourishes Blood; calms the spirit.	Poor appetite, tiredness and loose stools in Spleen-deficiency patterns.
 枸杞子 *Gou Qi Zi* Goji / wolfberry (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-b)	Sweet; neutral	Liver, Kidney	Nourishes Liver and Kidney; replenishes essence; supports vision.	Dizziness, aching lower back and knees, and impaired vision in Liver–Kidney deficiency patterns.
 罗汉果 *Luo Han Guo* Monk fruit (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Sweet; cool	Lung, Large Intestine	Clears heat; moistens Lung; lubricates the intestines.	Dry cough, sore throat and hoarseness in Lung-heat dryness; constipation from intestinal dryness.

Note. Herb photographs and traditional profiles are adapted from the Hong Kong Polytechnic University database (PolyU). Meridian names refer to TCM functional systems, and the applications describe traditional uses in their stated contexts.

A2 Eight reported product categories with illustrations

The eight categories follow presentation slide 4. The supplied photograph identifies Nature's Green Mind Soothe Capsules as the illustrated example for liver care and mood support. Details of mixtures and finished products are included where available in the field records.

Table A2 Illustrated profiles of the eight presentation product categories

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **Ginseng tonics** 人参 / 西洋参	Varies by formula.	Not recorded.	Staff linked use to fatigue, Qi support and immunity.	Staff described use for fatigue and general nourishment.
 罗汉果 **Monk-fruit products** Reference material: monk fruit (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Reference fruit: sweet and cool.	Reference fruit: Lung and Large Intestine.	Staff associated it with throat comfort and cooling.	Fruit and drink forms were described, with recipes unrecorded.
 花茶 / 凉茶 **Flower and herbal teas** Reference flower: chrysanthemum (PolyU, n.d.-e)	Mixture not recorded.	Mixture not recorded.	Staff described everyday wellness uses.	Staff linked simple brewing to younger buyers.
 药材汤包 **Soup packs** Fieldwork soup display 13 September 2026	Complete recipe unknown.	Formula not recorded.	Presentation: light nourishment.	Preselected dried packs still require cooking.

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **灵芝保健品** **Lingzhi supplements** Reference: Lingzhi (PolyU, n.d.-i)	Supplement formula unknown.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff associated supplements with immunity support.	Staff described use for general wellness and immunity support.
 **养肝 / 疏肝解郁** Nature's Green 绿叶 Mind Soothe Capsules Supplied photograph	Formula not recorded.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff described Liver nourishment and soothing constraint; the box uses "Mind Soothe" language.	Staff linked this category to late nights and stress.
 **银翘类** **Yin Qiao-type remedies** Reference: honeysuckle (PolyU, n.d.-k)	Exact formula unidentified.	Whole-product affinities unrecorded.	Staff associated this category with cold symptoms.	Staff described use for cold symptoms.
 **红花油 / 红油精** **Medicated oils** External example (Fei Fah, n.d.)	Topical formula unidentified.	No meridian assigned.	Staff associated oils with aches and injuries.	Staff described external use, including by older customers.

Note. Uses follow the interview or presentation. The Nature's Green box is a supplied product photograph; the other reference illustrations are identified in their rows. Complete product formulas were not recorded during the visit.

A3 Five locally linked examples and production status

Table A3 separates local cultivation, manufacture and packaging. Nature's Green is the brand of the pictured Mind Soothe Capsules. HSA lists the capsules as a Singapore-manufactured Chinese Proprietary Medicine (HSA, 2025b); their ingredient origins were not recorded.

Table A3 Locally linked examples retained from the presentation

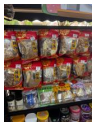
Example	Raw origin and grown in Singapore	Manufacture in Singapore	Processing packaging or brand link
 **Cactus 仙人掌** (NParks, n.d.-b)	Named as a possible locally grown example; origin of stock unknown	Not established	No specific product or producer identified.
 **Roselle 洛神花** (NParks, n.d.-a)	Named as a possible locally grown example; origin of stock unknown	Not established	No specific product or producer identified.
 **Mind Soothe Capsules 舒肝解郁胶囊** Nature's Green 绿叶 Finished CPM	Ingredient origins and Singapore cultivation are unverified.	HSA lists Tong Jum Chew as manufacturer and Singapore as the manufacturing country (HSA, 2025b).	Nature's Green is the brand of this finished Chinese Proprietary Medicine.
 **Five Flower Tea 五花茶** (Wing Joo Loong, n.d.)	Not established	Not established	Locally linked in the presentation; item-specific processor, packer and brand unknown.
 **Monk fruit tea 罗汉果茶** Reference: monk fruit (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Not established for the tea product	Not established	Locally linked in the presentation; item-specific processor, packer and brand unknown.

Note. NParks supplies the reference plant photographs. The cactus species and stock origins were not identified in the interview. The Five Flower Tea image is an external product example, and the monk-fruit image shows a reference ingredient. HSA supplies the manufacturing information for the Nature's Green capsules.

A4 Five soup therapies retained from the presentation

The five labels follow slide 6. Staff named Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates and goji as common soup ingredients. Table A4 records the named ingredients and the presentation's descriptions of nourishment and everyday care.

Table A4 Soup labels ingredients and reported purposes

Soup label	Ingredients available from the record	Purpose and main use
 **Qing Bu Liang 清补凉** Field display context only	Complete recipe not recorded	Light nourishment and everyday care in the presentation.
  **Dang Shen and Huang Qi soup** **党参北芪补气汤** Named ingredients only	Dang Shen and Huang Qi are named; complete recipe unknown	Qi support and nourishment in the presentation.
  **Yu Zhu and Huai Shan soup** **玉竹淮山润燥汤** Named ingredients only	Yu Zhu and Huai Shan are named; complete recipe unknown	Moistening and nourishment in the presentation.
  **Goji and red date soup** **枸杞红枣养生汤** Named ingredients only	Goji and red dates are named; complete recipe unknown	Everyday nourishment and health maintenance.
 **Five Finger Fig soup** **五指毛桃健脾汤** Reference root only (DH, n.d.)	Five Finger Fig is named; other ingredients not recorded	Spleen and digestive support in traditional terms.

Note. Images show named materials, not complete formulas or finished soups. PolyU supplies Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, goji and red dates (n.d.-m, n.d.-l, n.d.-g, n.d.-f, n.d.-b, n.d.-d); Hong Kong's Department of Health (DH, n.d.) supplies Five Finger Fig root. The Qing Bu Liang image shows field display context only.

A5 Three comparatively lower-demand examples with illustrations

The lower-demand examples follow presentation slide 8: one named herb and two broader product categories. Their descriptions come from staff and the presentation, without a numerical sales ranking.

Table A5 Illustrated profiles of the lower-demand examples

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **半枝莲 Ban Zhi Lian** **Barbated skullcup herb** Reference material (PolyU, n.d.-c)	Sweet, bitter and cold.	Liver, Lung and Kidney.	Reference: clears heat and toxins, resolves stasis and promotes urination.	Reference uses include sores, throat swelling and oedema.
 **Specialist herbs** Requiring combinations	Varies by formula.	Varies by formula.	No combination was identified.	Staff described a need for preparation and guidance.
 **大补方** **Strong tonic formulas** Tonic material illustration only (PolyU, n.d.-h)	Formula not recorded.	Formula not recorded.	Presentation: intensive replenishment 大补.	The presentation associated lower appeal with suitability and climate.

Note. Ban Zhi Lian properties come from PolyU. The specialist-herb photograph shows the field cabinet, and the ginseng image illustrates a tonic material. Specific combination and tonic formulas were not recorded.

A6 Staff-described product uses without confirmed clinical prescriptions

Staff described the six product associations below, retained from slide 9. Physician presence at the outlet was unclear, and we recorded no clinical prescriptions or patient cases. Table A6 therefore presents the interview's retail descriptions.

Table A6 Staff-described product uses without confirmed clinical prescriptions

Complaint or wellness concern	Associated retail product	Clinical details not recorded
Colds	Yin Qiao type remedies	Formula and patient assessment not recorded.
Diarrhoea	Huoxiang Zhengqi type remedies	Formula and patient assessment not recorded.
Fatigue or Qi deficiency language	Ginseng or Dang Shen	Staff used fatigue and Qi-support language; no patient assessment recorded.
Perceived lower immunity	Lingzhi or supplements	Staff described immunity support; no patient assessment recorded.
Late nights stress and long work hours	Liver care or mood support products	Staff linked use to daily pressures; no diagnosis recorded.
Aches or injuries	Medicated oils	Staff described external use; no injury assessment recorded.

A7 Survey coverage and sources

Table A7 Survey coverage and details not recorded

Survey item	Record retained	Location	Details not recorded
A	Eight herb entries; nine reference profiles	A1; Section 3.1	No verified twelve-month sales ranking.
B	Eight product categories	A2; Section 4	Exact products and comparative sales unknown.
C	Five locally linked examples	A3; Section 5.1	Capsule manufacture corroborated; other origins unverified.
D	Five soup labels	A4; Section 3.2	Complete recipes and all pack identities unconfirmed.
E	One named herb and two categories	A5; Section 4.3	No verified bottom-three ranking.
F	No physician prescriptions recorded	A6; Section 7	Physician role not confirmed; no clinical cases recorded.
G	Six separate retail associations	A6; Section 6.1	No physician-treated cases recorded.

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Appendix B Fieldwork photographs

Figure 1

Soup promotion in the neighbourhood retail setting



Note. Branded soup packs and a family cooking image at the shop frontage. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.

Figure 2

Preselected dried soup ingredients in branded packs



Note. Preselected dried ingredients in Tong Keow soup packs. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.

Figure 3

Herb labels and retail quality claims



Note. Cabinet labels for American ginseng and sulphur-free Dang Shen. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.